

GUEST COLUMN
TEESTA SETALVAD



PARTNERS IN CRIME

playing a match where the opposition had not even turned up. With the elections round the corner, it suits everyone to have the Marathi vote-bank split between Shiv Sena and the MNS. Says Sanjay Raut, Rajya Sabha MP and Shiv Sena spokesperson: "The rise of the MNS will damage the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) the most, as their performance is dependent on this segment. The next to suffer will be the BJP as wherever they are contesting in the state, the Marathi *manoos* vote will go to the MNS as Sena won't be contesting in that seat."

While bigwigs like NCP chief Sharad Pawar continue to believe that Raj is nothing more than nuisance and is best ignored, it is precisely that attitude which has emboldened the MNS leader to accelerate his campaign of hate. Already, the damage done by the violent outbursts by his unruly cadre is evident. Earlier, anyone from outside Maharashtra, who made Mumbai or the state his home, could visit the beach or roam around the streets without any fear. Today the 'outsiders' are living in terror, wondering when the next attack will come.

What started out as a race between two competing Thackerays—Raj and Uddhav—has now snowballed into a national crisis with Mumbai as their playground. Much of the blame for that lies with politicians from all parties, the state leadership and even the Centre. Home Minister Shivraj Patil comes from Maharashtra and should be taking the lead in bringing Raj to heel. Instead, he is playing the Invisible Man. The chief minister is at loggerheads with his own

Slow poison not just kills, but cripples and warps permanently. The slow poison—the hate-ridden violence, which is the accepted dark underbelly of the so-called urbs prima of the country—has snatched away from Mumbai its numero uno status. Major collaborators in this decline are an elite from the same class, which generations back, built up this unique mosaic of class(es), faiths and cultures. With one difference. Today the collaborators have also been injected by the cancer of hatred, segregation and violence. The decline did not burst upon us overnight. It has crept upon us as on most of the upper crust of Mumbai, and India participate and collaborate in the division and violence.

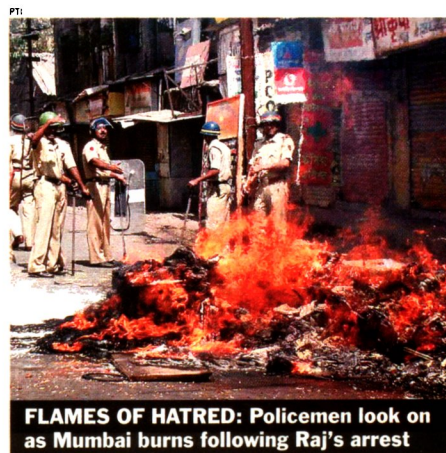
The collapse of constitutional governance has tarred Indian democracy over decades. The trend was, sadly, heralded in through its urbs prima. Remember December 1992 and January 1993? When a son of Bombay's soil Ratan Tata wept as he saw his city torn asunder amid the shanties at Asia's largest slum, Dharavi? Then it was the uncle behind the destruction (Justice B.N. Srikrishna report). Today it is the nephew Raj

Thackeray. Carrying forward his uncle's legacy, Raj has voiced his brand of vitriol, burnt property, caused deaths of innocents and yet has, so far, escaped the clutches of law. Despite two arrests, courts have been generous in granting him bail.

At the heart of this breakdown of constitutional governance is the tepid reaction of our society, institutions and authorities to hate campaigns. We have strong laws but these are not invoked. In 1992-1993

Bal Thackeray's hate speech not only destroyed property worth Rs 1,100 crore but even targeted our courts. "*Mein adalaton ke phaisle par laghoo shanka karta hoon* (I piss on the judgments of the courts, *Saanj Jansaata*, June 25, 1993)," said the senior Thackeray. Both the uncle and nephew have been encouraged by the inaction of our otherwise zealous judiciary to hold the Mumbaikar to ransom.

Who is responsible for the utter breakdown of the rule of law in Maharashtra? A complicit state government that has cynically cultivated the Shiv Sena (and now the MNS) since the mid-'60s? A police that has been injected with the hate virus? Generously blind courts that do not see hate speech worthy of suo moto action? In short, each and all of us who loftily applaud 60-odd years of Indian democracy.



FLAMES OF HATRED: Policemen look on as Mumbai burns following Raj's arrest



The author is the co-editor of Communalism Combat